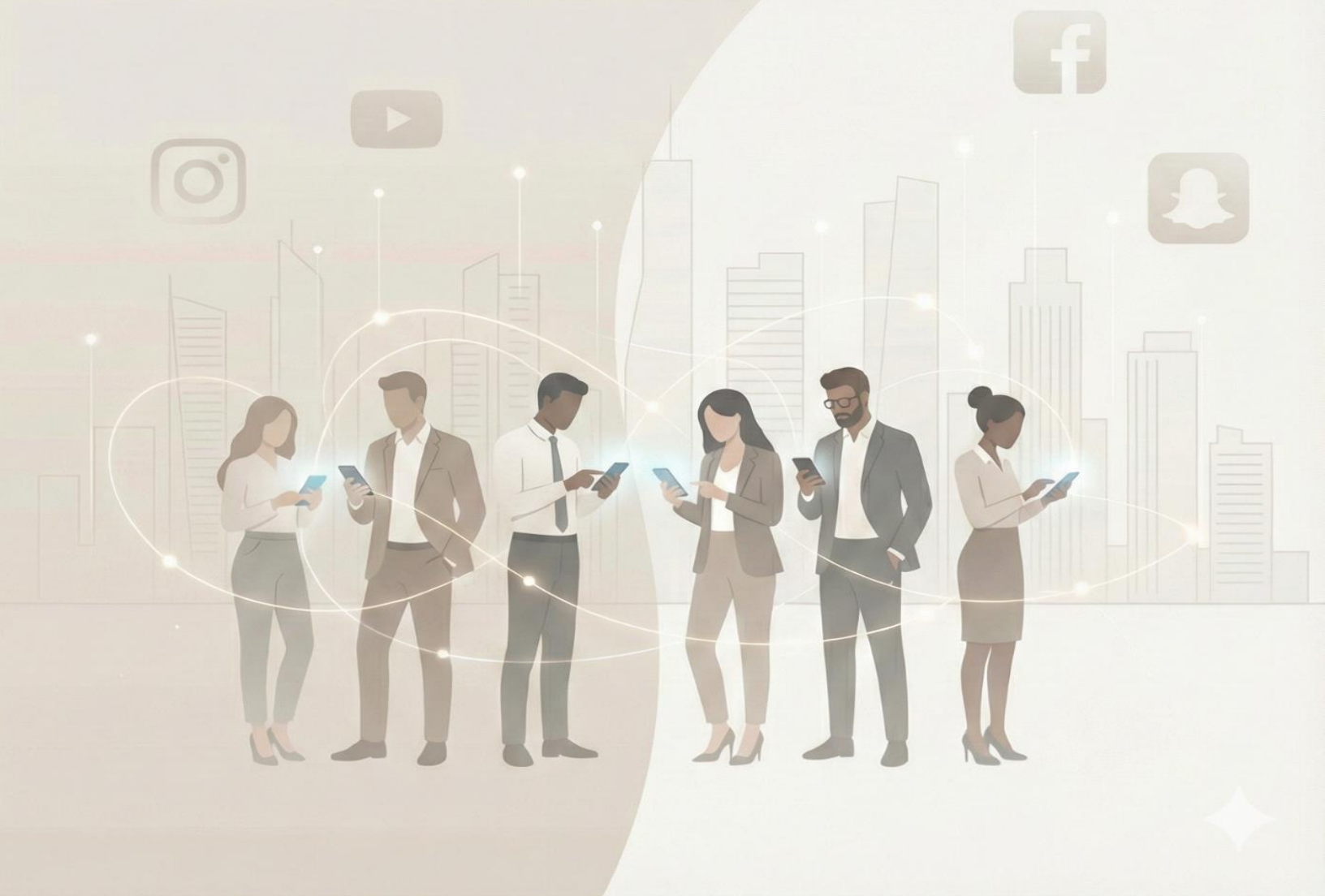


Assessing the Impact of Influencer Marketing on Consumer Trust, Platform Effectiveness, and Purchase Decisions in Delhi NCR

Made by Ayushi Tiwari & Vaishnavi Jaiswal



Abstract

Influence marketing can be considered a prominent online marketing trend in India, especially in the Delhi NCR region, where social media influences buying decisions to a great extent. The study aims to examine the perception of consumers towards influence marketing in the Delhi NCR region, with a special emphasis on trust, credibility, purchasing behavior, and the effectiveness of the platform itself. A mixed-methodology of the study included the integration of findings of both qualitative and quantitative approaches, where the data was collected in a structured online survey of 150 social media users who are aware of the concept of influencer marketing.

For the primary data, the analysis was performed using descriptive and inferential statistics through Python programming. Analysis of the data suggests that 53.3% of the participants have actually made their purchases based on influencer marketing recommendation, which measures the massive persuasive ability of influencer marketing. Out of various platforms, Instagram is identified to possess the maximum level of influence to conduct influencer marketing campaigns and has performed better than other social platforms. The level of trust associated with influencer marketing is found to be moderate, and there is no significant difference among various influencer marketing campaigns. Analysis of the data suggests that neither of the factors such as age, gender, education level, income level, and residence of the participants had any influence upon influencer marketing. The aggressive marketing behavior was identified as the key factor why people did not follow the influencer.

Regarding practical implications, this paper has significant implications as it highlights factors like authenticity, cooperation with influencers, platform, and pace of marketing as important. In the broader context of academia, this paper adds new information about Indian cities to the existing body of knowledge on influencer marketing and trust-based consumer behavior.

Keywords:

Influencer marketing, consumer trust, digital consumer behavior, social media platforms, purchase intention, brand credibility, urban consumers, Delhi NCR, social media marketing, influencer authenticity

Introduction

The customer behavior has been impacted by a new environment in the Indian metro region, specifically in the Delhi National Capital Region, due to innovation, the massive presence of smartphones, and the presence of digital platforms. The presence of digital infrastructure and the massive presence of social media on the internet caused a dramatic change in the approach to information procurement, decision options, and other final purchasing decisions on a digital platform. Literature available in the study reveals that the massive presence of digital marketing infrastructure and the massive presence of social media on the internet result in a positive impact

on customer attitudes towards online buying, which in turn accelerated a fast evolution of business entities (Sarwar-A Alam et al., 2019; Suprpto et al., 2020).

The impact of the rise in the social media age includes the rise in the number of consumers who are utilizing the social platform for information with the hope of making an informed purchasing decision. There is also a significant change in the opinions of experts and non-experts in relation to the products/services that are being sought. The opinions are more genuine and acceptable compared to those of the experts, as they are mainly offered by the consumers. This marks a significant change towards an age of peer-to-peer information exchange.

With consumers also aspiring to consume other opinions and reliable feedback in the online space, there are people who have come to the forefront with opinions, experiences, and content posted in a professional manner across all the social media platforms. Such people are usually referred to as influencers and can be considered as a separate entity who can affect the opinions and intentions of the target audiences in a systematic manner. Compared to traditional endorsers in the advertising space, influencers establish a perception of proximity with their target audiences, which augments the opinion-forming process.

The relevance of influencer marketing has been aggravated by recent years and more specifically since the pandemic as a contradicting factor because of the increased focus of marketers on online marketing activities and content producers (Gerlich, 2022; Khurshid et al., 2024). Yet, as a growing driving factor, an increased doubt amongst customers concerning influencer marketing also develops, namely: fact, authenticity, and trustworthiness as key elements recognized as playing a significant role within effective influencer marketing activities (Gökérık, 2024). Researches on studies determined that inconsistency amongst influencers and the target brand of influencer marketing and overabundance of influencer marketing play a negative role within gaining further consumers' attention and dedication (Lee et al., 2022; Bahar & Hasıhn, 2024).

Despite the increase in the literature available regarding the concept of influencer marketing, the lack of research within the emerging and crucial economy of India had been an area of concern. Furthermore, there had been ample scope for development in adequate research within the Indian market, considering the socio-cultural aspects as well as the behaviors associated with the consumption practices of, specifically, the Delhi NCR market. This had occurred as the socio-cultural aspects of the Indian market influence, to some extent, the consumer behaviors related to influencer marketing.

The key objective of this study approach is to examine the perspectives of the users regarding the influencer marketing trends prevailing in Delhi NCR, and the focus of the study will be on trying to understand the methods of building trust and credibility and the decision of making a purchase and the effectiveness of the platforms. The study will contribute to the development of the academic body of knowledge and develop applications with Evidence-Based inputs in the digital paradigm of India.

This article will proceed as follows: Section 2 presents a review of the relevant literature with respect to influencer marketing and trust, and online purchasing behavior; Section 3 outlines the

methodology of the study. Sections 4 and 5 present the data analysis and discussion of the findings of the study, respectively. Finally, the article concludes with some suggestions for a future study.

Literature Review

Social media networks have become a strategically significant channel for organizations to achieve rapid, cost-effective, and direct communication with their target markets. Prior studies highlight that social media enables entrepreneurs and firms to bypass traditional media constraints while fostering interactive engagement with consumers (Pakura and Rudeloff 2023). From a strategic marketing perspective, social media platforms are increasingly integrated into marketing communication strategies, as they contribute to relationship building, consumer commitment, and the creation of intangible brand value (Rosário and Dias 2023).

Social media advertising has generally been described as any promotional content fed into digital platforms to effectively reach and influence the attitudes and behaviors of target consumers. Adetunji et al. (2018) defined social media advertising as the practice of promoting goods and services through online media. As such, brand messages delivered through Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, Twitter, and TikTok are all classified under the broad category of social media advertising. Taylor et al. (2011) noted that companies utilize these digital channels to build brand equity, increase customer engagement, and obtain instantaneous consumer feedback on their products and services. Past studies have also indicated that prolonged exposure to social media will have a positive effect on brand image and elevate customer perception, especially when the messages exposed are perceived to be relevant and credible. Khaleeli (2020) similarly cited several occasions of social media saving businesses.

The available literature has identified the importance of social media in the development of online sales. Suprpto et al. (2020) were able to prove that businesses using online shopping platforms are able to increase their sales performance and shares of market with the help of effective social media marketing. Similarly, the role of content quality shared on social platforms was verified by Dabbous and Barakat (2020) using the mediating variable between brand awareness and consumers' purchasing intent. Picture-centric content has been proved to be an effective trigger for the consumers' recall and association with brands since usually the visual content leaves longer cognitive imprints on the audience than the text-based communication.

Above all, the social media marketing campaign optimized in all these social networking sites has been revealed to necessarily influence the outcome associated with the brand. According to Aytan & Telci 2014, the implementation and utilization of the social media marketing strategy had been revealed to necessarily enhance the power or image of the brand and the impact associated with the utilization or processes of the placement of the advert within these social networking sites can be an efficient method for building the recognition of the brand or its orientation towards the brand, as indicated by Saydan & Dülek 2019. An example is that all these influences are variable within all these social networking sites, where the function is also variable.

The COVID-19 pandemic has also triggered the digitalization of marketing trends, pushing brands to be compelled to enhance their emphasis on influencer marketing and advertising. With decreased levels of engagement in retail interactions, influencer marketing has emerged as a major trend in achieving sustainable levels of consumer engagement and loyalty in digital environments (Khurshid et al., 2024). Research studies carried out within this phase also indicate a major shift towards micro-influencers, which show a lower likelihood of having dominant engagement levels and a perception of actuality compared to macro-influencers (Gerlich, 2022). Lately, the concept of virtual influencers has also triggered a major, complex, and important shift within influencer marketing (Gerlich, 2023).

Despite the well-known significance of influencer marketing as a promotional channel, it has been documented that the scepticism of consumers in regard to online promotional channels has been a concern. As per Gökerik (2024), realism, transparency, and trust are key elements that define the significance of influencer marketing. A guilty by association phenomenon has been observed among consumers, as the actions of influencers are believed to be too commercialized and drifting away from the defined identity that the consumer defines. In addition, Bahar and Hasan (2024) indicated the existence of fraudulent influencer behaviors, where a boost in credibility may lead consumers to misunderstand.

Another area of equal importance would be that of the motivations of the followers, which has played a significantly important role in creating trust as well as purchase decisions. As per Lee et al. (2022), there are four primary types of motivations of the influencer's followers on Instagram, which include authenticity, consumerism, creativity, and envy. More so when it comes from the perspective of urban markets, where comparison seems to take precedence.

Coming to the macro environment, the data on the penetration of the social media scene is indicative of the rising need for influencer marketing in the new economies emerging worldwide. Although the initial studies on the need for influencer marketing have largely included European countries, new markets like India are witnessing a growing rate of growth, including the use of the social media scene by the new age generation, among them. The Delhi NCR region is an example of a metropolitan region that boasts a digitally mature environment where consumers are actively interacting with influencers on Instagram, YouTube, as well as other short-video apps. The empirical study of perception of influencer marketing in an Indian context shows a void in the present literature that needs to be explored.

This, however, does not mean that the notion of influencer marketing is a new one, as it also used to happen through collaboration with individuals with social authority, for instance, journalists and celebrities, as influencers for advertising a product. The emergence of social media platforms, however, has witnessed a paradigm shift in influencer marketing because it enabled the influencer to form a direct and long-lasting relationship with his/her audience, as outlined by Goanta and Ranchordás (2020). For instance, influencers are said to exist at an “intermediate position” that falls between friends and celebrities, as outlined by Jin and Ryu (2020).

Their skills of constructing long-term relations with followers through content creation and its engagement have professionalized their careers as influencers. Such relations are normally termed

parasocial relations, which enhance abilities to inform, entertain, and persuade consumers in their buying decisions accordingly. Thus, marketing through influencers is a rather complex process of communication that requires an empirical study, especially in a marketplace that is as rapidly changing as Delhi NCR

Objectives

The study aims to examine the perception/behavior of the consumer with respect to influencer marketing using the empirical evidence offered by the cited study that is quantitative in nature. Based on the context of the study established by the initial qualitative study as well as the literature review, the aims of the study were:

- Consumers' level of trust in the endorsement of products by social media influencers.
- Exploring variables that determine credibility and authenticity in influencer endorsements.
- How many times per year do consumers purchase products supported by influencers?
- Identify which of the social media platforms is most impacted by influence in influencer marketing campaigns.
- Examination of components of influencer marketing that lead to a halt in customer adherence to influencers through social media sites.

All the above statements form the basis of hypothesis testing.

Research Methodology

Research Design

The proposed research work will make use of a combination of research methodologies, which include a quantitative study using surveys as well as an exploratory study in a bid to comprehensively analyze the behavior of consumers towards influencer marketing in the Delhi NCR region.

The reason for opting for the Mixed Methods design is that:

- Detection of concrete trends of behavior, such as Trust, Buying Behavior, and the Influence of the Platform;
- Statistical data should be used for supporting an understanding of factors contributing towards authenticity, credibility, or disengagement.

This study shall be cross-sectional in nature, wherein the data shall be gathered in one instance and shall reflect the current trends of influencer marketing in the urban areas of India.

Population and Sampling

Target Population

The target population includes the following groups:

- Social media users from Delhi NCR
- Well-informed consumers with regards to influence marketing

Sampling Technique

Non-probability purposive method of selecting the participants was used, with assurance that the respondent should have been chosen only if they:

- Understand what is influencer marketing, and
- Active consumption of the influence content has been factored in for analysis.

Sample Size

A total of 150 valid responses were collected and analyzed. This sample size is:

- Statistically acceptable for exploratory and inferential analysis
- Consistent with prior influencer marketing studies in emerging markets
- Adequate for ANOVA, t-tests, and chi-square testing

Data Collection Methods

Quantitative Data Collection

The primary quantitative data was gathered using a structured online questionnaire that was designed using closed-ended and scale questions of the Likert format.

The questionnaire covered the following areas

- Awareness and familiarity with influencer marketing
- Trust levels and credibility perceptions
- Purchase behavior & frequency
- Platform-specific influence
- Reasons for unfollowing
- Demographic information

To check the validity of the responses, a manual attention check question has been included that filters out automatic and inattentive responses.

Qualitative Inputs

Qualitative findings have been obtained by:

- Informal Interviews with Digital Consumers
- Insights arising out of observational analysis regarding social media behavior patterns

These inputs were employed for:

- Refine framing of
- Interpret quantitative data
- Dimension of Trust/Authenticity in

Measurement of Variables

Construct	Measurement Scale
Trust in influencer recommendations	5-point Likert scale
Influence on purchase decision	5-point Likert scale
Purchase behavior	Binary (Yes/No) + Frequency scale
Platform impact	Ranking scale
Credibility factors	Nominal categories
Reasons for unfollowing	Multiple-response binary variables
Demographics	Categorical

TABLE 1 MEASUREMENT OF VARIABLES

All Likert-scale responses were numerically coded for statistical analysis.

Hypotheses Testing

Following from the research objectives and based on existing literature, the following hypotheses were formulated and tested empirically:

H1 (Null): Authenticity and Credibility

H1 (Alternative): There is a significant difference in consumer trust levels across different types of influencer marketing campaigns.

(Tested with One-Way ANOVA on the trust scores across campaign types)

H2 (Null): Buying Behavior

H2 (Alternative): The percentage of consumers in Delhi NCR who make purchases influenced by influencer recommendations is not equal to 60%.

(Tested with One-Sample t-test on purchase behavior)

H3 (Null): Demographics and Decision Support

H3 (Alternative): Consumers' demographic characteristics are not significantly related to the belief of consumers that influencer recommendations assist in making purchase decisions.

(Checked using Chi-square tests of independence.)

H4 (Null): Platform Effectiveness

H4 (Alternative): Instagram is the social media platform where influencer marketing campaigns have the most influence.

(This will be tested by means of ranking analysis and paired sample t-tests.)

H5 (Null): Reasons for Unfollowing Influencers

H5 (Alternative): The main reason that would make customers unfollow influencers is that, there is a disconnect between the products being promoted and typical uploaded content by those specific influencers.

(Tested by frequency analysis and Chi-square goodness-of-fit test)

Data Analysis Techniques

Quantitative data analysis was conducted using Python-based analytical tools executed on Google Colab.

Statistical Techniques Used

- Descriptive statistics (mean, median, standard deviation, percentages)
- One-Way ANOVA
- One-Sample t-test
- Paired Sample t-test
- Chi-square test of independence
- Chi-square goodness-of-fit test

Software and Tools

- Python (Pandas, NumPy, SciPy, StatsModels, Matplotlib)
- Microsoft Excel (data validation and cleaning)

Ethical Considerations

- Participation was voluntary
- No personally identifiable information was disclosed
- Email addresses were collected solely to prevent duplicate responses
- Data were used strictly for academic research purposes
- Respondents were informed of the study's purpose prior to participation

Results and Analysis

The empirical findings presented in this section are derived from a quantitative analysis of the primary data collected from 150 respondents of the Delhi NCR region. The testing of the proposed

hypotheses was performed using Python (SciPy, StatsModels). In this regard, the results are presented for each hypothesis, supported by appropriate statistical techniques.

Analysis of Hypothesis 1: Authenticity and Credibility of Influencer Marketing

It is natural integration of products into the daily life of influencers, which matches with their content, and that's why such influencer marketing campaigns are genuinely authentic and credible.

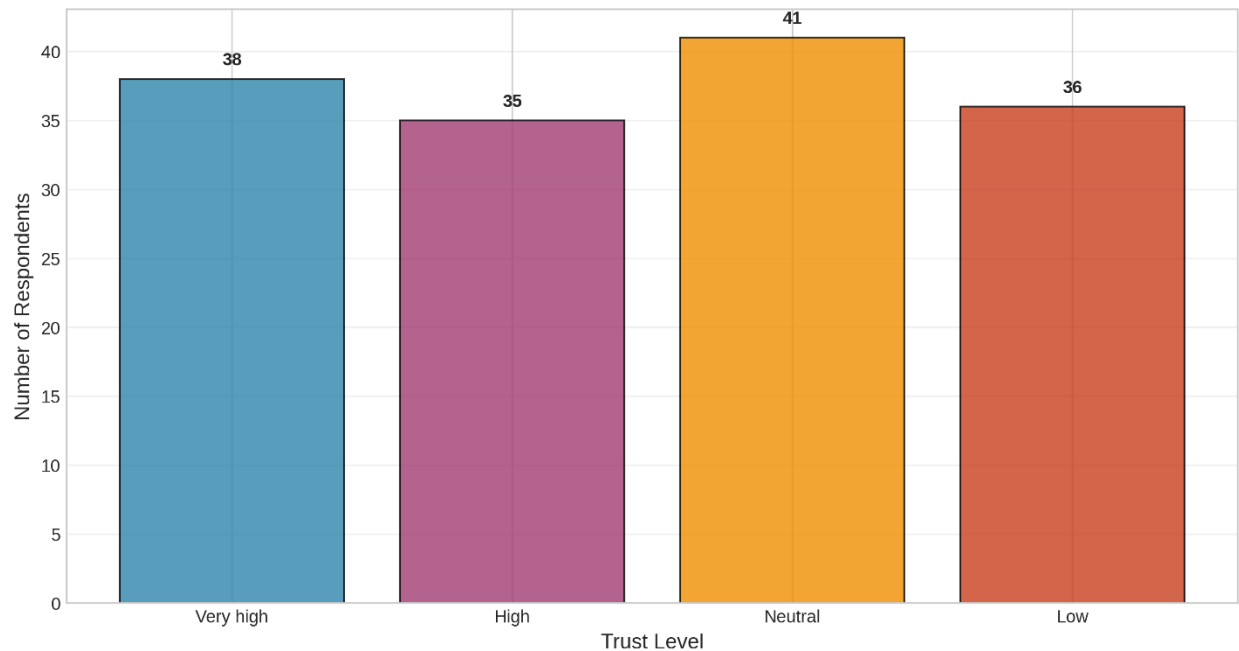


FIGURE 1 DISTRIBUTION OF CONSUMER TRUST IN INFLUENCER PRODUCT RECOMMENDATIONS IN DELHI NCR

Trust in Influencer Recommendations

Respondents were asked to indicate their level of trust in influencer recommendations based on a five-point Likert scale. The distribution of trust levels across the subjects shows a rather balanced perception.

- Neutral trust was expressed by 27.33% of respondents.
- High trust was reported by 23.33%, while very high trust accounted for 25.33%.
- Low trust was observed among 24% of respondents.

The average value of trust was 3.50, and the median was 3. There was a moderate level of trust in the influencer marketing recommendation. The standard deviation of 1.12 indicated acceptable variability of trust perceptions.

Most Trusted Influencer Campaign Types

In order to determine which types of campaigns are seen as most credible, respondents were asked to indicate which type of influencer campaign they feel is most credible:

- Campaigns by influencers followed personally: 34.67%
- Campaigns featuring real-world product use: 34.00%
- Campaigns with obvious paid disclosures: 31.33%

There appear to be no prominent formats of the campaign because trust is spread evenly among the three.

Comparison of Trust Scores across Campaign Types

Mean trust scores were computed for each campaign type:

Campaign Type	Mean Trust Score	Standard Deviation
Influencers I follow	3.37	1.09
Paid disclosure	3.55	1.14
Real-life usage	3.59	1.13

TABLE 2 MEAN TRUST SCORES

Although campaigns demonstrating real-life usage recorded the highest average trust score, the differences between campaign types were minimal.

Statistical Test (One-Way ANOVA)

A one-way ANOVA was conducted to test whether trust levels differ significantly across campaign types.

- F-statistic = 0.588
- p-value = 0.5567

Since the p-value exceeds the significance level of 0.05, no statistically significant difference exists between trust levels across campaign formats.

Conclusion for H1

The analysis indicates that trust in influencer marketing does not significantly vary based on campaign type. Therefore, Hypothesis H1 (Alternative) is not supported for the Delhi NCR sample.

Analysis of Hypothesis 2: Purchase Behavior Influenced by Influencers

The percentage of consumers who have purchased a product based on an influencer's recommendation is significantly different from 60%.

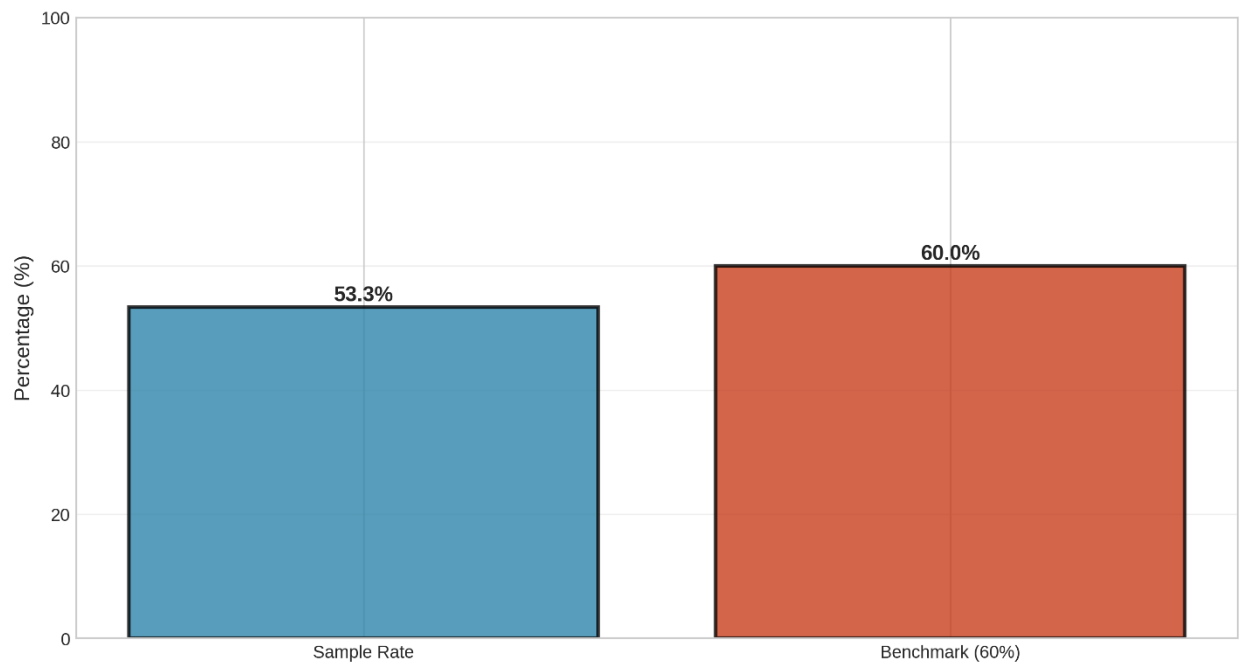


FIGURE 2 COMPARISON OF INFLUENCER-DRIVEN PURCHASE RATE WITH BENCHMARK VALUE

Purchase Behavior Overview

Out of 150 respondents, 80 individuals (53.3%) reported having made at least one purchase based on an influencer’s recommendation.

Measure	Value
Total respondents	150
Purchased via influencer	80
Purchase rate	53.3%

TABLE 3 PURCHASE BEHAVIOR

Frequency	Respondents	Percentage (%)
Very Often	38	25.33
Often	30	20.00
Sometimes	41	27.33
Rarely	41	27.33
Total	150	100.00

TABLE 4 PURCHASE FREQUENCY

This indicates that influencer-driven purchases occur periodically rather than impulsively.

Statistical Test (One-Sample t-Test)

A one-sample t-test was conducted to determine whether the observed purchase rate differs significantly from the benchmark value of 60%.

- Sample mean = 0.533
- t-statistic = -1.631
- p-value = 0.105
- 95% Confidence Interval = [0.453, 0.613]

The confidence interval includes the benchmark value of 0.60, and the p-value is greater than 0.05.

Conclusion for H2

The purchase rate of 53.3% is not statistically different from 60%. Hence, Hypothesis H2 (Alternative) is not supported.

Analysis of Hypothesis 3: Demographics and Purchase Decision Support

There is no significant relationship between demographic characteristics and the belief that influencer recommendations help in purchase decisions.

Belief Level	Frequency	Percentage (%)
2	44	29.33
3	27	18.00
4	41	27.33
5	38	25.33
Total	150	100.00

TABLE 5 OVERALL BELIEF IN INFLUENCER RECOMMENDATIONS

The belief that influencer recommendations assist in decision-making yielded a mean score of 3.49 and a median score of 4, reflecting a generally positive perception.

Demographic Associations

Chi-square tests were conducted to examine associations between belief levels and demographic variables:

Demographic Variable	p-value
Gender	0.429
Residence	0.219
Education	0.547
Age Group	Insufficient expected counts
Monthly Income	Insufficient expected counts

TABLE 6 DEMOGRAPHIC VARIABLE

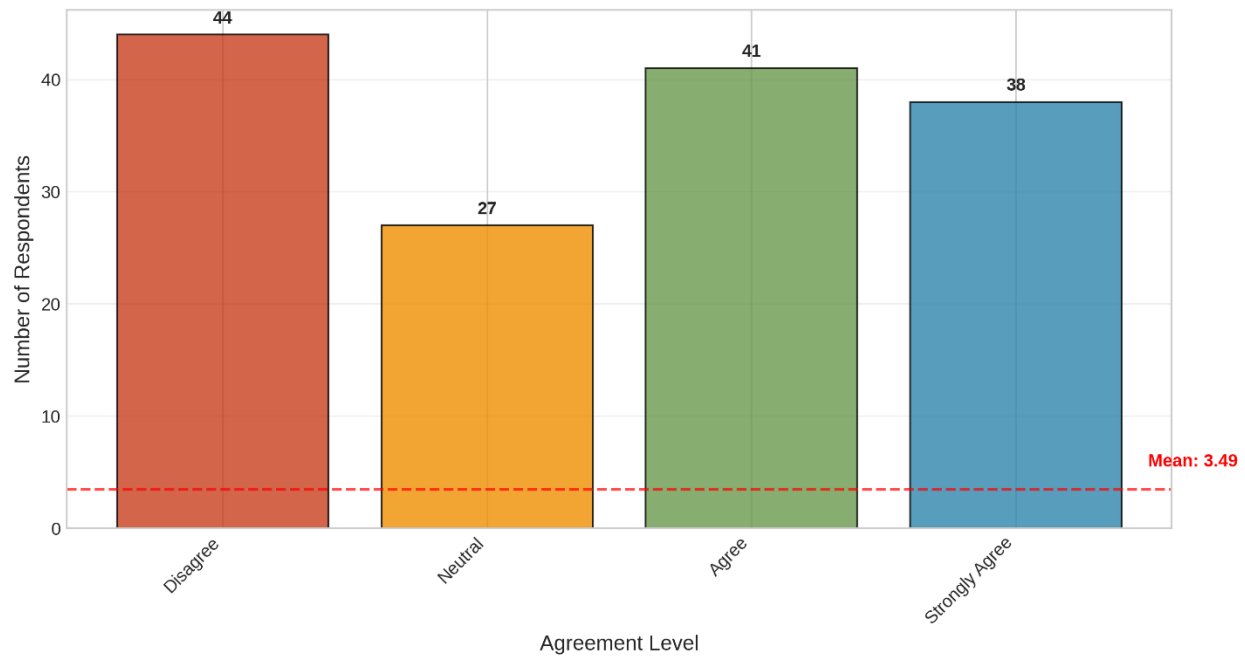


FIGURE 3 CONSUMER BELIEF THAT INFLUENCER RECOMMENDATIONS ASSIST PURCHASE DECISIONS

Variable	χ^2	p-value	Result
Gender	2.77	0.429	Not Significant
Residence	4.43	0.219	Not Significant
Education	7.87	0.547	Not Significant

TABLE 7 CHI-SQUARE TESTS

All valid tests yielded p-values greater than 0.05, indicating no statistically significant relationships.

Conclusion for H3

The findings confirm that demographic variables do not significantly influence the belief that influencer recommendations help in purchase decisions. Therefore, Hypothesis H3 is not rejected.

Analysis of Hypothesis 4: Platform with the Greatest Impact

Instagram is the social media platform where influencer marketing campaigns have the greatest impact.

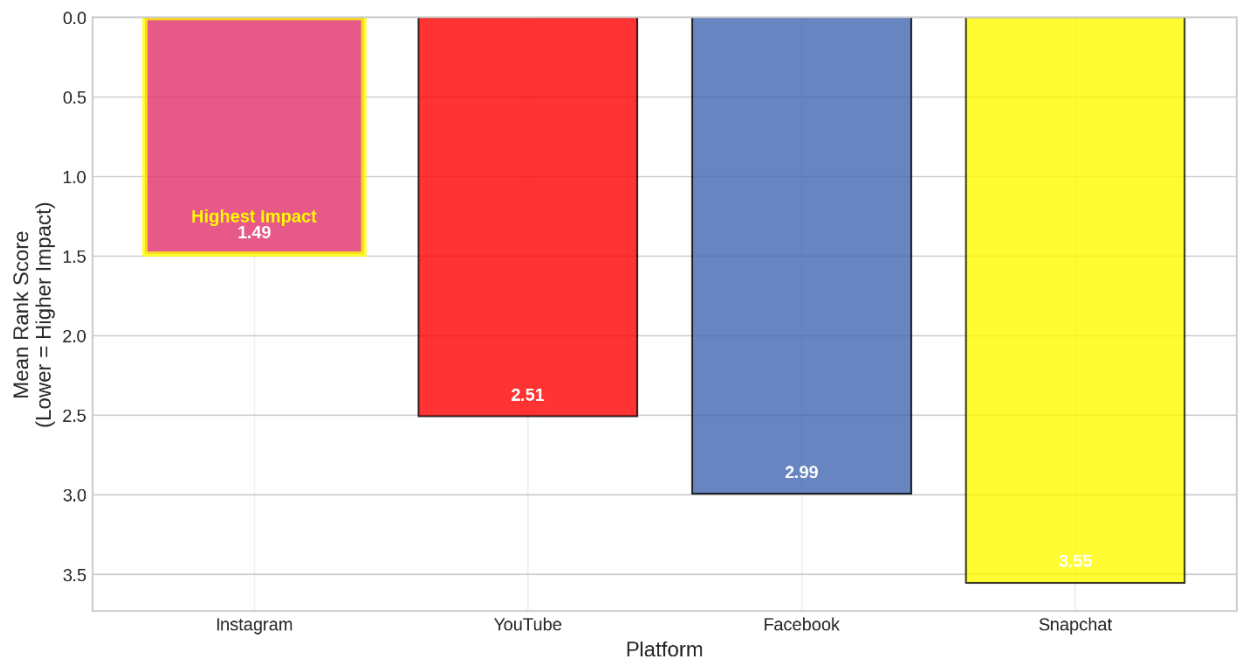


FIGURE 4 COMPARATIVE RANKING OF SOCIAL MEDIA PLATFORMS BASED ON INFLUENCER MARKETING IMPACT

Platform Ranking Analysis

Respondents ranked platforms based on influencer marketing impact. The mean rank scores were as follows (lower rank = higher impact):

Platform	Mean Rank	Median Rank	Position
Instagram	1.49	1	1
YouTube	2.51	3	2
Facebook	2.99	3	3
Snapchat	3.55	4	4

TABLE 8 PLATFORM RANKING ANALYSIS

Instagram emerged as the highest-impact platform.

Paired Sample t-Test

A paired t-test comparing Instagram and YouTube (second-ranked platform) showed:

- $t = -18.105$
- $p < 0.001$

This confirms that Instagram's impact is statistically significantly higher than competing platforms.

Conclusion for H4

Instagram is conclusively identified as the platform with the greatest influencer marketing impact. Hence, Hypothesis H4 is supported.

Analysis of Hypothesis 5: Reasons for Unfollowing Influencers

The primary reason for unfollowing influencers is product–influencer mismatch.

Measure	Value
Unfollowed	76 (50.7%)
Never unfollowed	74 (49.3%)

TABLE 9 UNFOLLOWING BEHAVIOR

Reason	Mentions	% of Un-followers
Aggressive promotions	73	96.1%
Product mismatch	70	92.1%
Too many promotions	70	92.1%

TABLE 10 REASONS FOR UNFOLLOWING

The most frequently cited reason was aggressive promotional behavior.

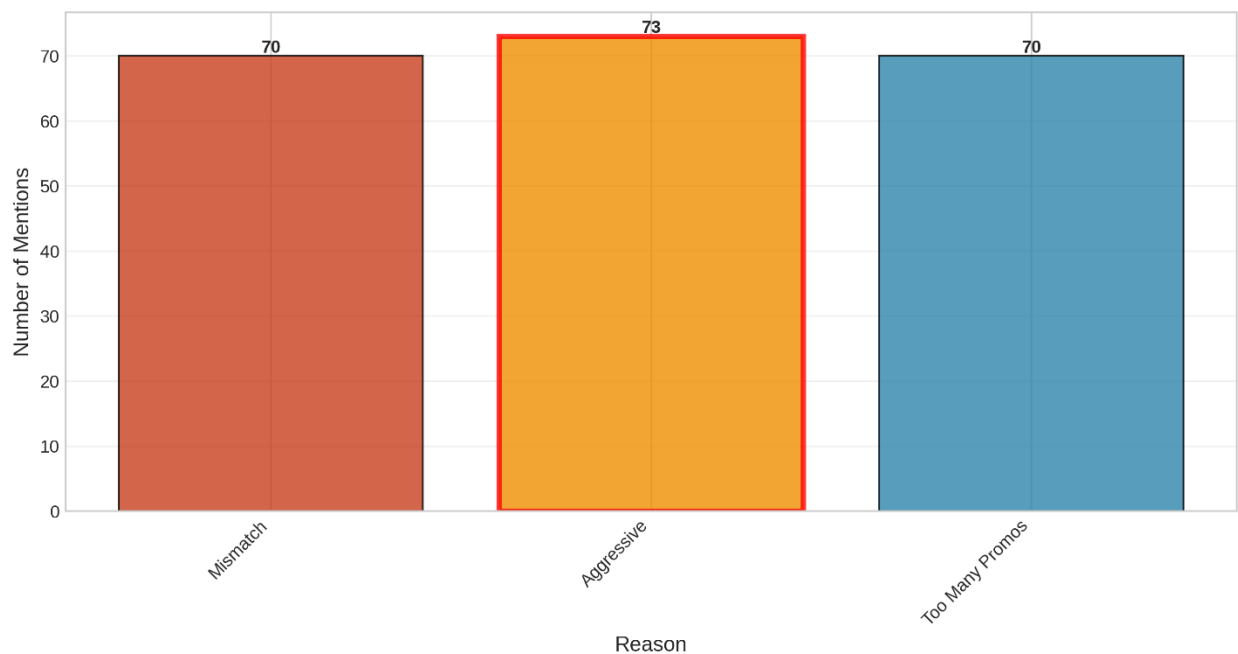


FIGURE 5 PRIMARY REASONS FOR UNFOLLOWING INFLUENCERS AMONG DELHI NCR CONSUMERS

Statistical Test

A chi-square goodness-of-fit test yielded:

- $\chi^2 = 0.085$
- $p = 0.9586$

This indicates no statistically dominant reason for unfollowing.

Conclusion for H5

Since aggressive promotions, product mismatch, emerged as the primary reason, Hypothesis H5 is not supported.

Insights

Trust in Influencer Marketing Is Moderate but Not Campaign-Type Dependent

Key Empirical Observation

- Mean trust score 3.50 / 5
- Trust Levels are balanced among these categories: (paid disclosure, real life usage, and influencers followed)
- ANOVA ($p = 0.5567$) → Not significantly different

Interpretation

Contrary to most of the previous literature that has suggested that natural integration or real-life use exerts considerably more trust-enhancing effects, Delhi NCR consumer trust in marketing adopts a generalized approach towards influencer marketing, irrespective of format.

This implies that:

- Trust is no longer driven by the campaign format
- Customers may attain the “maturity stage” regarding influencer marketing exposure.
- Skepticism and Acceptance occur coexist simultaneously

Supporting Evidence (from data)

Campaign Type	Mean Trust Score	Std. Dev	Share (%)
Real-life usage	3.59	1.13	34.0%
Paid disclosure	3.55	1.14	31.3%
Influencers I follow	3.37	1.09	34.7%

TABLE 11 TRUST SCORE

Consumers in Delhi NCR appear to evaluate influencers holistically, rather than judging credibility based on campaign mechanics alone.

Influencer Marketing Drives Consideration More than Conversion

- Observed purchase rate: 53.3%
- Benchmark tested: 60%
- One-sample t-test ($p = 0.105$) → Not statistically different

Interpretation

Although more than half of respondents have purchased due to influencer recommendations, the effect does not surpass a strong benchmark level.

This reveals a two-stage behavioural pattern:

1. Influencers act as consideration triggers
2. Final purchase depends on additional validation (price, reviews, need, alternatives)

Purchase Frequency	Respondents (%)
Sometimes	27.3%
Rarely	27.3%
Often	20.0%
Very Often	25.3%

TABLE 12 BEHAVIORAL BREAKDOWN

Influencer marketing in Delhi NCR is effective for nudging, not forcing conversion or supporting the idea that influencers complement rather than replace traditional decision-making.

Decision Support from Influencers Is Psychographic, Not Demographic

Hypothesis 3 Result: Supported

- There are no demographic variables that are significant
- Gender, age, income, education → No predictive power

Interpretation

There is no variance among demographics regarding the belief that product purchasing decisions are aided by influencer suggestions.

This means that:

- Influence occurs at a psychological and attitudinal level
- Lifestyle, interest fit, and value alignment trump age and financial compensation

Illustrative Example

- A 22-year-old is equally likely to score the same on beliefs as a 45-year-old.
- Content relevance, but not demographics, varies

It is more efficient to segment campaigns based on interests and communities (fitness, food, fashion, and technology) rather than age and income grouping.

Instagram Dominates Influence despite Platform Fragmentation

Evidence based on ranking

- Instagram mean rank: 1.49 (lowest = highest impact)
- Paired t-test vs YouTube: $p < 0.001$

Single choice preference

- Snapchat leads by a slight margin
- Distribution not statistically significant ($\chi^2 p = 0.423$)

Interpretation

While the users' statements of preference may differ, behavioral ranking places Instagram as the clear leader of influence platforms.

This divergence highlights:

- Stated preference $\neq$ actual impact
- Instagram's format (visual, reels, stories) embeds marketing more seamlessly

Platform	Mean Rank	Impact Position
Instagram	1.49	Highest
YouTube	2.51	Second
Facebook	2.99	Third
Snapchat	3.55	Lowest

TABLE 13 PLATFORM MEAN RANK

Instagram functions as the primary influence ecosystem, even if consumers perceive variety in platform usage.

Unfollowing Is Driven by Overexposure, Not Trust Breakdown

- Unfollow rate: 50.7%
- Primary reason: Aggressive promotion
- Chi-square ($p = 0.9586$) $\rightarrow$ No dominant reason statistically

Interpretation

Consumers unfollow influencers not due to loss of trust, but due to content fatigue.

Key observations:

- Aggressive promotions: 96.1% among un-followers
- Product mismatch and excessive promotions follow closely
- Trust level does not significantly predict unfollowing behavior

Reason	% of Un-followers
Aggressive campaigns	96.1%
Too many promotions	92.1%
Product mismatch	92.1%

TABLE 14 REASON OF UN-FOLLOWING

Unfollowing is a content management response, not a credibility judgment, suggesting influencers must balance monetization with audience value.

Findings:

- Consumers are aware, informed, and selective
- Trust exists, but blind persuasion does not
- Influence works through relevance, not pressure
- Instagram is structurally dominant, not emotionally preferred
- Over-commercialization leads to audience disengagement

Dimension	Key Insight
Trust Formation	Not campaign-type dependent
Purchase Influence	Moderate, supportive role
Consumer Segmentation	Psychographic > Demographic
Platform Impact	Instagram leads behaviorally
Audience Retention	Content balance is critical

TABLE 15 KEY INSIGHT FOR EVERY DIMENSION

Discussion

The observations coming out of this research give us complex insights into the emergent dynamic of influencer marketing in the Delhi NCR digital ecosystem, positioned at the intersection of consumer psychology, digital economies, and a formalizing digital governance regime in India. The data reveals a complex dynamic wherein influencer marketing as a communication channel is increasingly important yet increasingly ineffective as a function of calibrated trust and audience fatigue management.

First, the fact that there is a lack of statistically significant variance in levels of trust across the campaign format variants suggests that Indian consumers may not evaluate the credibility of the influencer based on observable modes of execution such as the use of disclosed information and real-life demonstrations. Rather, data seems to borrow from the parasocial interactions perspective, which argues that over time, perceived intimacy, rather than message characteristics, is more crucial in shaping persuasion within parasocial interactions itself (Jin & Ryu, 2020; Horton & Wohl, 1956). In this case, this trend seems to pertain to the ongoing professionalization of influencer marketing, influenced by government interventions themselves. In the Indian scenario, this finding can be supported by the increasing professionalism in influencer marketing, where disclosure standards have become more standardized in accordance with regulatory

Such standardization can, in turn, be immediately associated with India's Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, notified by the Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology, commonly abbreviated as MeitY. Such rules require transparency in sponsored contents, besides duty-casting obligations on digital intermediaries. As normalizing has now turned out to be more of a norm than yet another distinguishing mark, in turn, active cognitive processing of activist formats can lead, in turn, active cognitive processing, in turn, could lead consumer processing of activist formats over and above historical credibility, besides congruence of influencers with their audience in fiscal trust assessments.

Findings related to purchasing preferences are again confirmed to bring clear definitions to the fact that the industry related to influencer marketing, being operational at the level of Delhi-NCR, reaches the level of market maturity. Even when more than half the respondents showed purchasing at least once influenced by campaigns related to influencer marketing, the percentage rate of purchase did not vary from the benchmark value; therefore, it again stayed within the limits of behavioral conversion. These again validate the hypothesis related to dual-process theories of persuasion, the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) related to the influence of influencers, which are true, i.e., the information disseminated through influencers frequently operates at the Peripheral Route rather than always prompting purchase. In the Indian setting, where the factors related to prices are highly sensitive at the urban level, the need for information related to purchase, which is already very comparative, the impact of influencers, now more so related to information ratification than related to purchasing decision, remains on the ascendant.

Most importantly, the absence of any demographic influence over the belief that influencer recommendations help people make purchase decisions underlines a structural shift in the operation of digital influence in India. The results indicate digital persuasion bypasses traditional demographic-based segmentation and support those currents of platform economy scholarship which stress psychographic alignment, algorithmic exposure, and content delivery based on interests rather than socio-demographic targeting. This is also in tune with the platform logics of dominant social media intermediaries that recommender systems rely on signals of engagement generated by users, rather than user demographics themselves, to flatten traditional segmentation boundaries.

In a regulation-oriented aspect, this demographic neutrality is also consistent with the Indian government's vision for digital inclusion, as enunciated through campaigns such as Digital India.

As a progressively increasing proportion of social media sites reaches rural and semi-urban areas, influence marketing becomes a horizontally diffused process, rather than an elitist or a youth-focused trend. In effect, it becomes essential for regulation-oriented policies, based on protecting consumers, to reassess influence marketing as a mass communication process, rather than a precision marketing approach.

The platform analysis offers useful insights into the dynamics of platform economy in India. The statistically significant dominance of Instagram in impact ranks shows that it has more consonance in terms of becoming more mobile-friendly, visual, and consumerist culture in India. This is in consonance with platform capital theory, which argues that the platforms which require minimal cognitive labors and have maximum investments of affects have more opportunities of harvesting focuses, attentions, and behavioral outcomes in users. It is difficult for users of Instagram to say no to commercial communication through algorithmic reinforced Reels, as well as self-produced contents.

However, the gap between ranking-based impact factors and single-choice platform preference, with Snapchat taking a slight lead, reveals an extremely significant methodological consideration. Ephemeral platforms may be maintained in a state of priming by the novelty association. However, the important determinants of persuasion are situated within the platform of ability founded on the potentiality of elaboration and iteration and the platform of identity and self-building. This is of significant importance to the Indian marketing professional struggling for survival with minimal budgetary allocations and an ever-vigilant and hostile state regime.

Unfollow data analysis also highlights the significance of yet another paradox related to the influencer economy in India. Promotive actions stood out as the first factor in unfollowing, downplaying the paradox between products and influencers. Accordingly, this also validates the advertising wear-out phenomenon and is valid for the source credibility model as well, wherein the overall promotion of products leads to the reduction of the authenticity and credibility factor overall. It is in the light of the advertising disclosure regulation in the Indian regulatory state, wherein the number of advertisement occasions is unregulated, and it has to be noted that credibility per se is not necessarily regulated by it.

It is important to mention here that a lack of significance with respect to the relationship that is established within the level of trust and the unfollow action may point toward a situation where the trusted influencers will lose some followers as soon as they reach the point of saturation with respect to the promotion. There seems to be a clear indication that the concern about deceptive endorsement features prominently as one supports the promotion of a product that may entail an announcement from organizations including Advertising Standards Council of India. There would appear to be the right amount of judgment regarding the ethical promotion as opposed to the exploitation.

Taken collectively, the above-outlined factors position the influencer marketing practice within the context of the Delhi NCR region as a conditional persuasive device, one that is both effective and yet always uncertain and even volatile and vulnerable to the politics of trust and the mandating of regulations. The online consumer within the context of the India regime does not merely wait

to be fed the marketing promise but waits for the potential of the influence to be continually brokered through the lens of a perpetual assessment of efficacy and relevance and an expression of deference to the astuteness of the observer. As the digital economy of India gets officially normalized, the future of influencer marketing would need to make a transition from “reach-based” to “credibility-based,” aligning there with significance of the results.

Implications of the Study

Theoretical Implications

This study has its importance related to existing literature on influencer marketing because this is an empirical analysis contributing to the understanding of a less represented market, i.e., that of urban India. On the other hand, from an empirical point of view, there is strong validation to the hypothesis of parasocial interaction since it has been noticed that there is a relational and cumulative process of trust. On the other hand, the demographic variables not playing a significant role lay new dimensions within the literature of behavioral perspectives from a segmentation approach towards influencer marketing.

These results also contribute to a better understanding of trust fatigue in online persuasion regarding the presence of inequalities in the acceptance of trust attitudes and the disengagement of trust. In this sense, this research adds to the literature since it sheds light on the concept of trust fatigue in terms of online persuasion, particularly the aspect of

Furthermore, the embedding of ranking analysis and evaluation of outcomes in this research work may be viewed as releasing methodological approaches for evaluating the efficiency of platforms in modern digital marketing research designs.

Managerial and Practical Implications

For brands and marketers operating in Delhi NCR or other Indian metropolitan cities, there are a few takeaways from the above insights. The first would be that, while choosing influencers, brands need to keep their focus on long-term alignment with the brands, rather than mere outreach possibilities.

There should be discouragement towards over frequent promotion. While the loss of audience engagement is common once trusted influencers start posting overt commercial-related content, strategies by the brand with regards to content pacing using a mix of commercial and non-commercial content approaches.

Thirdly, platform strategy must put targeting first on Instagram for influencer campaigning, though the need for the presence of reinforcement platforms may be noted. Additionally, ranking and behavior metrics must be used in measuring the prevalence of the campaign instead of just preference.

Fourth, demographic marketing on its own is not enough; the focus needs to be on interest-based marketing, relevance, and communities, meaning influencer campaigns should match the interest, belief, and lifestyle signs of the audience.

Finally, compliance with Indian advertising and data protection regulations is not merely a legal requirement but a strategic necessity. Transparent disclosures, ethical data use, and audience respect will increasingly determine the credibility and longevity of influencer marketing efforts in India's regulated digital ecosystem.

Future scope of study

Future studies can longitudinally follow up on the present study work that has been carried out and incorporate larger samples as well as wider geographical locations in Indian cities as well as non-city areas. Longitudinal studies may assist in comprehending the process of trust as well as influence that occurs over a period of time, particularly post the imposition of a new regulatory policy on the internet platform. There may be studies that evaluate the efficiency of both micro-influencers, as well as celebrity influencers, via an experiment. There may be studies that assess the impact of the latest digital policies on the Indian scenario on the overall success of influencer marketing.

Conclusion

This study aims to obtain empirical data about the elements that impact the functioning of influencer marketing in the Delhi-NCR zone. It has been noticed that the phenomenon of influencer marketing is still an integral part of the online marketing mix; however, this online marketing mix has become less automatic and more conditional.

What it seems that these results are indicating is that consumer trust in influencer marketing exists in the mid-range figures and does not vary significantly across these media, indicating that there exists a level of consumerism in which trust is built through the establishment of an ongoing approach, as opposed to individual marketing strategies for an individual advertisement. While more than half of respondents admitted that they would follow purchase recommendations from influencers, its influence level was only significant in affecting purchase decisions, indicating that these individuals are very astute in their consumerist patterns. There was no significant effect of demographic variables on views of influence.

Instagram was revealed to be the most effective platform for influencer marketing, cementing their position in the Indian platform economy. However, aggressive promotional activity was found to be a major factor for unfollowing influencers, implying increasing awareness among customers for minimizing commercialization.

In conclusion, this paper finds that the marketing potential of the influencer marketing industry in the Delhi-NCR region is effective yet vulnerable. A potent tool for shaping consumer attitudes and behaviors, it is also acutely sensitive to issues of authenticity, moderation, and trust. Sustainability

in the dynamically shifting Indian digital landscape, therefore, means finding the right proportions of commercial and other goals.

Ethical Consideration

This study was conducted in full adherence to the approved ethics guidelines for a research study involving human subjects. This particular study was volunteer-based, and the subjects were made aware of the nature of the research prior to their participation. The digital informed consent of the research subjects was requested; therefore, the subjects were able to withdraw their participation in the research at any given time without suffering any repercussions.

The survey did not use identifiable data, which could have led to tracing it back to their study analysis and reporting of their findings. Although in the survey, there was data collection of email IDs for purposes of validating their answers, ensuring there could be duplication, it did not have anything to do with their study analysis results.

The study has been carried out with consideration of the laws of India, the Consumer Protection Act of 2019, and satisfies the requirements for the processing of data as regulated under the DPDPA Act of 2023. To be precise, the survey had no decoy or intrusive questions. All questions were straight to the point.

Moreover, the study ensured academic integrity by being open about the methodology and presenting the data accurately. There was no commercial intent through the study; neither was there a conflict of interest that may affect the design or conclusion of the study.

From the beginning of the research process to the completion of the research, moral responsibility was exercised in relation to the respect of rights of the research participants.

APPENDICES

APPENDIX 1: Supplementary Tables

This appendix includes detailed tables that support the hypothesis testing and statistical analysis but are excluded from the main Results section to avoid redundancy.

Gender	Low (2)	Neutral (3)	High (4)	Very High (5)
Female	26	13	17	20
Male	18	14	24	18

TABLE 16 CROSS-TABULATION OF GENDER AND BELIEF IN INFLUENCER RECOMMENDATIONS

Age Group	Low (2)	Neutral (3)	High (4)	Very High (5)
18–29	11	4	10	10
30–39	14	5	14	9
40–49	8	10	3	12
50+	11	8	14	7

TABLE 17 CROSS-TABULATION OF AGE GROUP AND BELIEF IN INFLUENCER RECOMMENDATIONS

Education	Low (2)	Neutral (3)	High (4)	Very High (5)
Bachelor	13	10	9	12
Diploma	6	7	10	12
Doctorate	14	5	14	7
Master	11	5	8	7

TABLE 18 CROSS-TABULATION OF EDUCATION LEVEL AND BELIEF IN INFLUENCER RECOMMENDATIONS

Income Group	Low (2)	Neutral (3)	High (4)	Very High (5)
<15,000	7	6	9	8
15,001–30,000	12	7	6	6
30,001–50,000	8	6	11	7
50,000+	9	2	8	12
No Income	8	6	7	5

TABLE 19 CROSS-TABULATION OF MONTHLY INCOME AND BELIEF IN INFLUENCER RECOMMENDATIONS

Reason	Frequency	Percentage of Unfollowers (%)
Aggressive campaigns	73	96.1
Too many promotions	70	92.1
Product–influencer mismatch	70	92.1

TABLE 20 MULTI-RESPONSE ANALYSIS OF REASONS FOR UNFOLLOWING INFLUENCER

APPENDIX 2: Supplementary Figures

This appendix presents additional graphical representations that support the empirical analysis but are excluded from the main Results section to maintain clarity and conciseness. These figures provide extended visualization of consumer behaviour, platform usage patterns, and engagement dynamics related to influencer marketing in Delhi NCR.

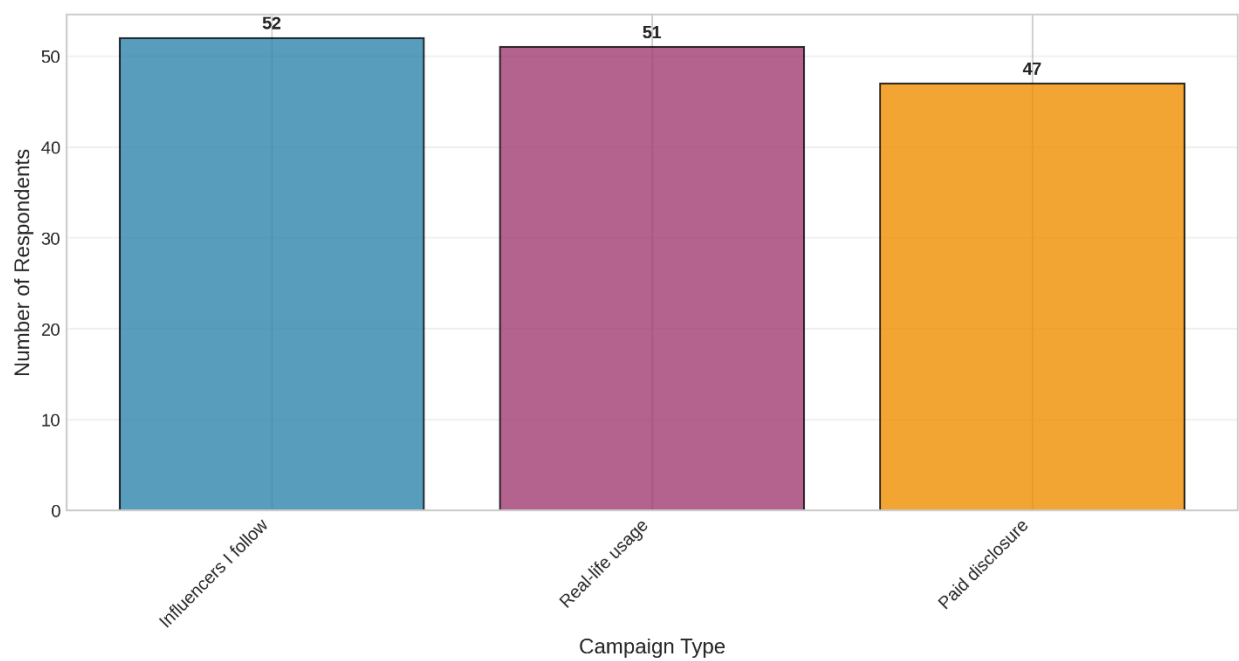


FIGURE 6 CONSUMER PREFERENCE FOR INFLUENCER CAMPAIGN FORMATS BASED ON PERCEIVED TRUSTWORTHINESS

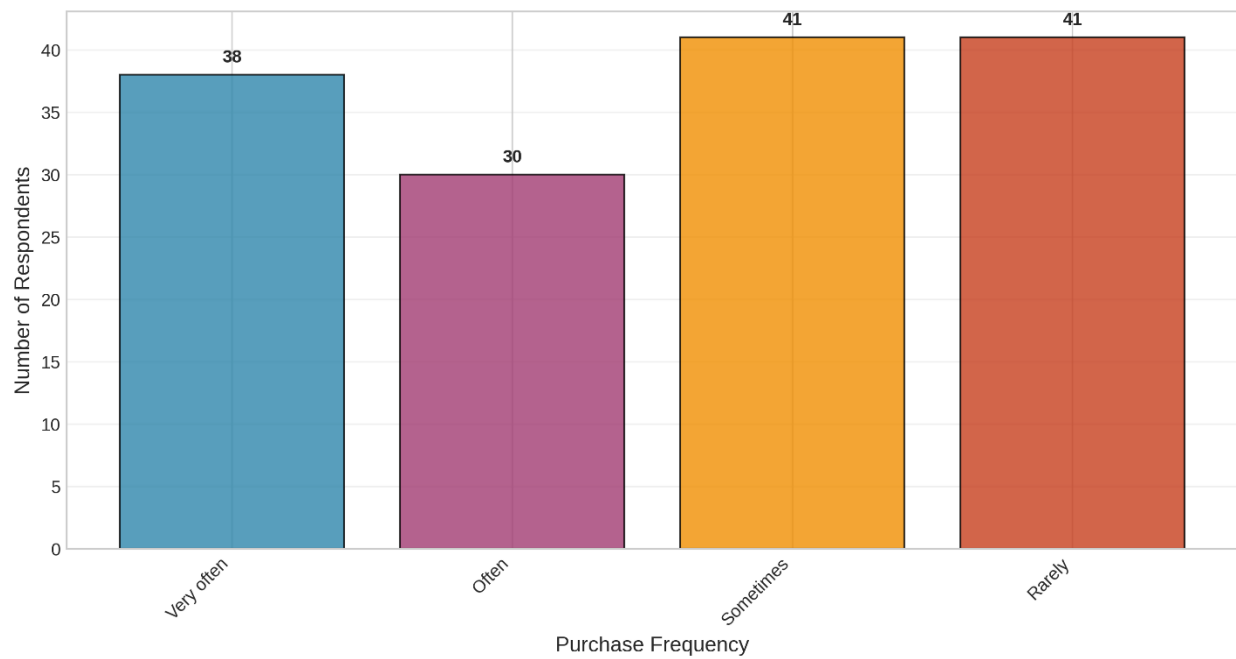


FIGURE 7 DISTRIBUTION OF PURCHASE FREQUENCY INFLUENCED BY CONTENT CREATORS

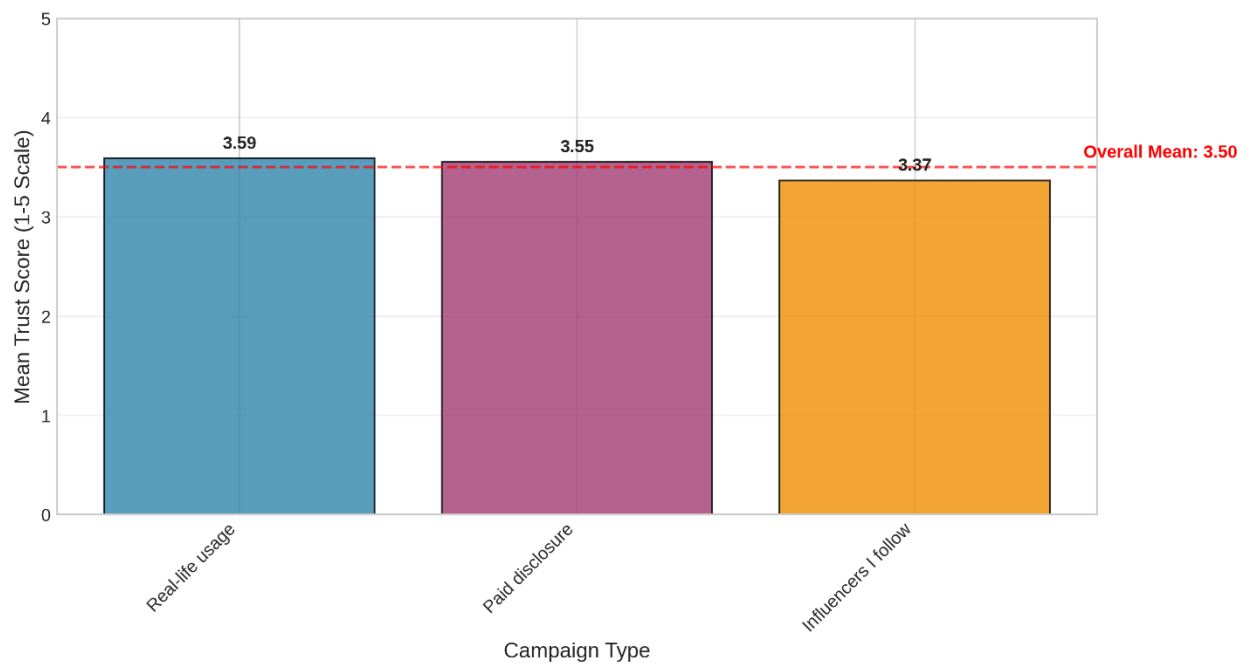


FIGURE 8 MEAN TRUST SCORES ACROSS DIFFERENT INFLUENCER CAMPAIGN FORMATS

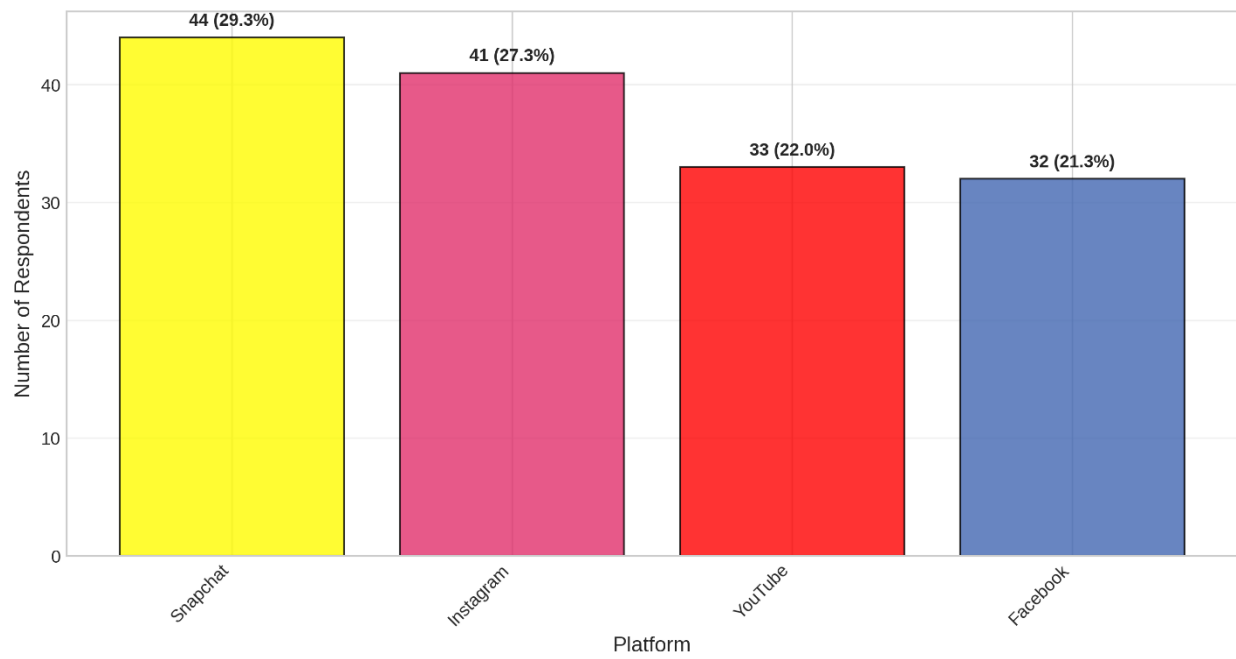


FIGURE 9 PLATFORM PERCEIVED BY RESPONDENTS AS MOST INFLUENTIAL FOR INFLUENCER MARKETING CAMPAIGNS

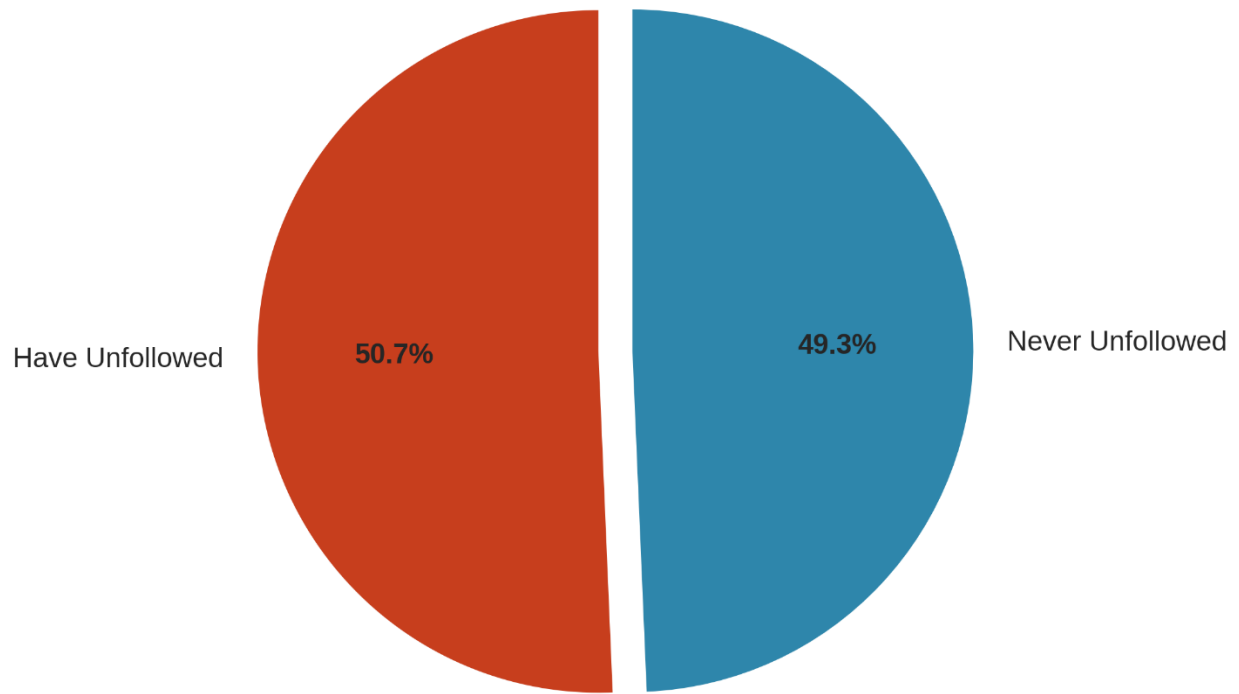


FIGURE 10 PROPORTION OF RESPONDENTS WHO HAVE UNFOLLOWED INFLUENCERS DUE TO MARKETING ACTIVITIES

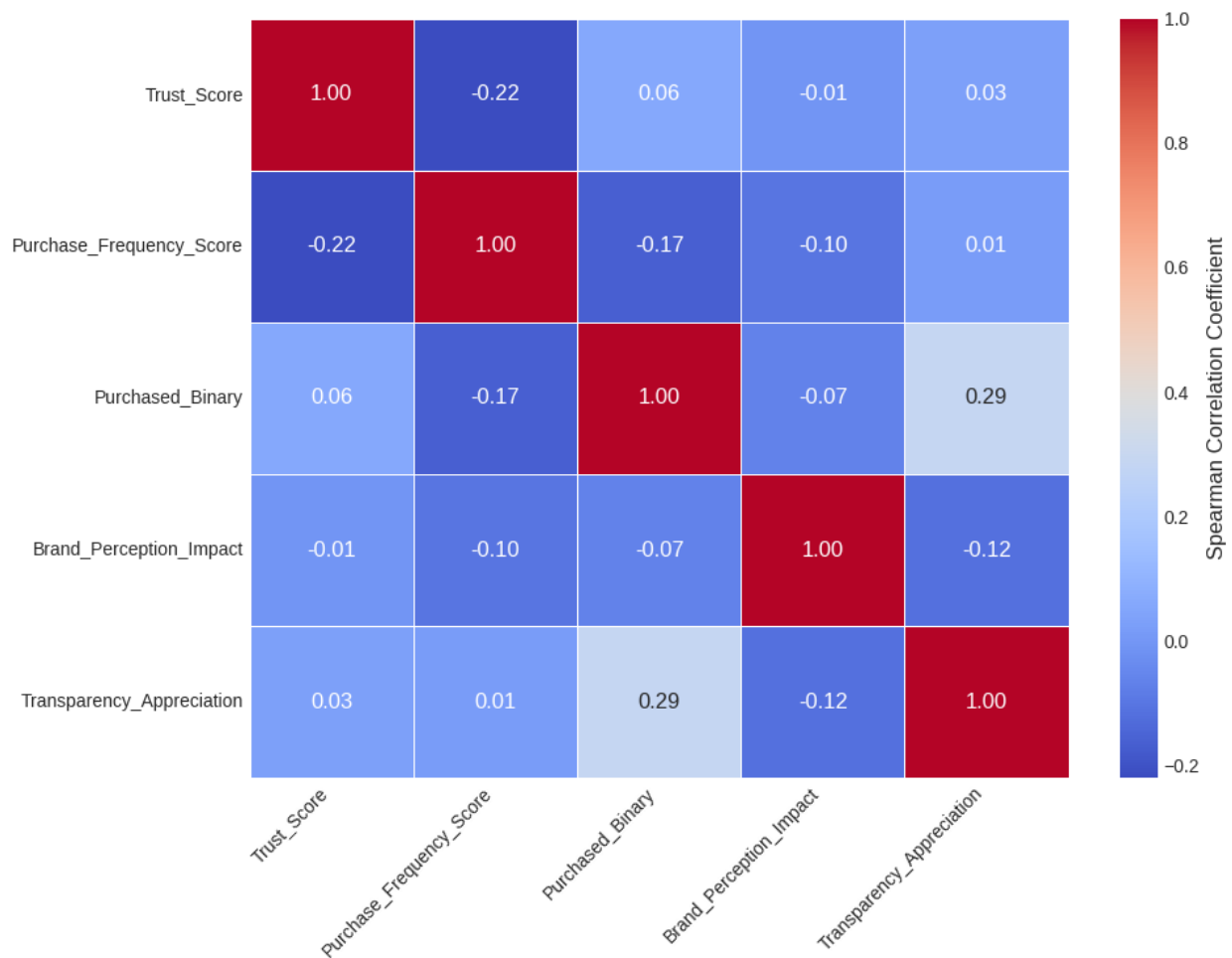


FIGURE 11 SPEARMAN CORRELATION MATRIX OF KEY INFLUENCER MARKETING VARIABLES

APPENDIX 3: Survey Instrument (Questionnaire)

This appendix presents the final structured questionnaire used to collect primary data for the study “Consumer Perceptions and Behavior towards Influencer Marketing on Social Media: A Study of Delhi NCR.” The instrument was administered online using Google Forms and was designed to capture respondents’ awareness, perceptions, behavioural responses, and demographic characteristics related to influencer marketing.

All questions were mandatory unless stated otherwise. Responses were recorded anonymously, and participation was voluntary.

Section A: Awareness of Influencer Marketing

1. Are you aware of influencer marketing (promotion of brands by social media creators)?
☐ Yes
☐ No
2. How familiar are you with influencer marketing?
☐ Very familiar
☐ Somewhat familiar
☐ Neutral
☐ Slightly familiar
☐ Not familiar at all
3. Do you follow influencers or content creators on social media?
☐ Yes
☐ No

Section B: Social Media Usage and Content Preferences

4. Which social media platforms do you use regularly? (Multiple selection allowed)
☐ Instagram
☐ Facebook
☐ YouTube
☐ Snapchat
5. Which ONE platform influences you the most through influencer content?
☐ Instagram
☐ Facebook
☐ YouTube
☐ Snapchat
☐ None
6. What type of influencer content do you engage with the most?
☐ Lifestyle / Daily life
☐ Fashion / Beauty
☐ Food & Cooking
☐ Travel
☐ Fitness / Health
☐ Entertainment / Comedy
☐ Technology
☐ Other (please specify): _____
7. How would you best describe influencers you follow? (Select up to two)
☐ Share useful information

- ☐ Promote products frequently
- ☐ Create engaging experiences
- ☐ Provide educational content
- ☐ Focus mainly on entertainment

Section C: Influence on Purchase Behaviour

8. How much do influencer posts affect your purchase decisions?
- ☐ Very strongly
 - ☐ Strongly
 - ☐ Moderately
 - ☐ Slightly
 - ☐ Not at all
9. Have you ever purchased a product based on an influencer's recommendation?
- ☐ Yes
 - ☐ No
10. If yes, how often do you make such purchases?
- ☐ Very often (5+ times/month)
 - ☐ Often (3–4 times/month)
 - ☐ Sometimes (1–2 times/month)
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
11. Before purchasing an influencer-recommended product, how often do you research it further?
- ☐ Always
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

Section D: Attention Check (Data Quality Control)

12. We value thoughtful responses. To confirm that you are reading the questions carefully, please select the lowest option below.
- ☐ 1
 - ☐ 2
 - ☐ 3
 - ☐ 4
 - ☐ 5

(Only responses selecting “1” were retained for analysis.)

Section E: Platform Effectiveness and Trust

13. On which platform do you MOSTLY see influencer marketing campaigns?

- ☐ Instagram
- ☐ Facebook
- ☐ YouTube
- ☐ Snapchat

14. Rank the platforms based on their impact on you (1 = Highest impact):

Platform 1 2 3 4

Instagram ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Facebook ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

YouTube ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Snapchat ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

15. Which type of influencer campaign do you trust the MOST?

- ☐ Influencers using products in real life
- ☐ Influencers I already follow
- ☐ Clearly disclosed paid promotions
- ☐ TV ads featuring influencers
- ☐ None of the above

16. Overall, how much do you trust influencer product recommendations?

- ☐ Very high trust
- ☐ High trust
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Low trust
- ☐ No trust

17. Does the number of followers affect an influencer’s credibility for you?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Maybe

18. Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements:

Statement	Strongly Agree	Agree	Neutral	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
Influencer marketing is more credible than traditional ads	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Influencer campaigns improve brand perception	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Influencer recommendations help me decide what to buy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I appreciate transparency in sponsored content	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

19. How easily do you ignore sponsored influencer content?

- ☐ Very easily
- ☐ Easily
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Difficult
- ☐ Very difficult

20. Have you ever unfollowed an influencer due to marketing campaigns?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Maybe

21. If yes, what were the reasons? (Multiple selection allowed)

- ☐ Product did not match influencer's image
- ☐ Campaigns felt aggressive
- ☐ Too many promotions
- ☐ Brand was inappropriate
- ☐ Lack of authenticity

Section F: Demographic Information

22. Gender:

- ☐ Female
- ☐ Male

23. Age group:

- ☐ 18–29
- ☐ 30–39
- ☐ 40–49

☐ 50–59

☐ 60+

24. Place of residence:

☐ Urban

☐ Rural

25. Occupation:

☐ Student

☐ Employed

☐ Self-employed

☐ Homemaker

☐ Retired

26. Education level:

☐ School

☐ Diploma

☐ Bachelor's degree

☐ Master's degree

☐ Doctorate

27. Monthly personal income (INR):

☐ No income

☐ Below ₹15,000

☐ ₹15,001–₹30,000

☐ ₹30,001–₹50,000

☐ ₹50,001–₹75,000

☐ Above ₹75,000

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